



Asia Insights

Foreign Exchange - Asia ex-Japan

BI and RBI continued to drain their FX reserves aggressively in May

Relatively limited intervention by the remainder of AeJ central banks, as broad USD traded in a narrow range.

- BI and RBI responded to sustained FX depreciation pressures through aggressive FX/USD selling intervention in May, as USD/IDR and USD/INR broke new highs.
- Arguably, the recent, large drawdowns in their FX reserves could have pressured BI and RBI to take stronger measures, such as the off-cycle rate hike and concessional FX swap for FCNR(B) deposits, respectively.
- BOK's spot FX/USD selling intervention was rather limited, even as KRW depreciation pressures mounted.
- The PBoC, MAS, BOT and CBC accumulated limited FX reserves, as their currencies remained stable or even appreciated against USD (i.e., CNH and TWD).

Key observations

- Our estimates show that **BI was one of the most aggressive sellers of FX/USD within AeJ in May, at USD4.8bn** (~3.9% of April 2026 FXR; spot + forward). This brought BI's 2026 YTD intervention to USD21.2bn (~15.7% of 2025 FXR). Despite the heavy intervention, onshore USD/IDR traded to an all-time high of 17,887 in May, and then higher to 18,190 on 8 June 2026. Under the IMF's four FX adequacy measures, BI's FX reserve adequacy stood at 90% as of April. However, accounting for predetermined short-term drainage, the reserve adequacy deteriorates to 46%.
- The **RBI was also an aggressive seller of FXR in May**, totaling USD11.5bn (~2.1% of April 2026 FXR; spot only). Onshore spot USD/INR rose to an all-time high of 96.965 on 20 May, before paring back some gains to end the month at 95.0, likely on RBI's FX intervention (*Bloomberg*, 29 May). Overall, the RBI's 2026 YTD FX/USD selling intervention stood at USD49.1bn (~8.9% of 2025 FXR; spot + forward; forward until April 2026).
 - The RBI's net short forward book was reduced by USD7.8bn in April 2026, bringing the overall short forward book to USD95.3bn from USD103.1bn in March. We note that the RBI conducted a USD5bn buy/sell FX swap on 26 May, which will increase the size of RBI's short forward book (*ceteris paribus*).
- In **China**, we estimate the **PBoC net bought USD28.7bn of FX reserves in May** (0.8% of April 2026 FXR; spot only). Broad USD was 0.9% stronger in May; however, CNH strengthened by ~0.9% against USD, making it one of the best performing FX in AeJ in May. The PBoC and state banks might have bought FX/USD in the market to slow the pace of RMB appreciation. May FX deposit data showed that state banks accumulated another USD10.9bn of FX deposits, bringing a total of ~USD39.6bn of FX/USD accumulation by Chinese authorities in May (~1.2% of April FXR).

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Fig. 1: Estimated intervention by AeJ central banks^[1] in May

(USD bn)	CN	IN	ID	KR	PH	SG	TW	TH
May 2026 FX Reserves (USD bn)	3442	546	123	402	80	417	605	246
May intervention (spot & forward)	28.7	-11.5	-4.8	-1.4	-0.3	1.7	0.6	1.4
May intervention as % of Apr FXR	0.8%	-2.1%	-3.9%	-0.4%	-0.4%	0.4%	0.1%	0.6%
Month of recent peak in FX reserves	May-26	Jun-25	Dec-25	Nov-25	Oct-25	May-26	Feb-26	Feb-26
Drawdown after the recent peak in FX reserves (spot & forward)	-	-100.8	-21.2	-13.0	-11.8	-	-5.1	-1.0
Interv. since recent intensification in drawdown (spot & forward) % of FXR	-	-17.0%	-15.7%	-3.2%	-13.3%	-	-0.9%	-0.4%
2026 YTD Interv. as % of end 2025 FXR	1.7%	-8.9%	-15.7%	-0.9%	-11.3%	0.0%	-1.1%	0.3%
2026 YTD Interv. as a % of GDP	0.3%	-1.3%	-1.5%	-0.2%	-2.0%	0.0%	-0.7%	0.1%
2025 Interv. as % of end 2024 FXR	-2.4%	-8.4%	-17.4%	-7.1%	-7.7%	3.9%	1.3%	8.5%
2024 Interv. as % of end 2023 FXR	-0.3%	-15.0%	-0.2%	-2.8%	-7.5%	8.6%	-2.9%	2.6%
May foreign equity flow (A)	-	-4.9	-0.2	-27.9	-0.2	-	8.4	0.1
May foreign bond flow (B)	-	0.5	-0.2	7.8	-	-	-	-1.0
Basic Balance monthly average (C)	50.3	-10.6	-1.2	22.2	-1.9	14.4	13.2	1.8
Current Account monthly average	54.7	-9.8	-2.4	24.7	-2.4	8.7	16.3	1.0
FDI monthly average	-4.4	-0.8	1.1	-2.5	0.5	5.7	-3.1	0.8
Total of BB and foreign equity and bond flow (A+B+C)	50.3	-15.1	-1.7	2.2	-2.1	14.4	21.6	0.9
USD/Asia in May	-0.9%	0.1%	3.1%	2.3%	0.3%	0.1%	-1.0%	0.0%
Average Reserve Adequacy	98%	234%	88%	76%	144%	60%	117%	250%
Average Reserve Adequacy with a fixed exchange rate regime	71%	192%	71%	60%	114%	56%	95%	193%

Note: FX reserves data (spot and forward) is for May 2026 or the latest available. We have used actual FX intervention data where available for the BOK (to Q4 2025), CBC (to Q4 2025), the MAS (to H2 2025), and the RBI (to March 2026). FX forwards for May are available for the CBC and BOT, based on our estimates for BI (using FX swaps), and unavailable for the RBI, PBoC, BOK, BSP and MAS (only using adjusted spot reserves). The recent peak in FX reserves is the peak of headline FX reserves in the last 12 months. Bond data for Thailand from the BOT. India bond flow data from WFII. CA is based on Q3 2026 (Nomura forecast), divided by 3. FDI is last 4Q average divided by 4. Basic Balance is the sum of CA and FDI. Reserve Adequacy as of May2026.

Source: CEIC, Bloomberg, Nomura.

1. For BOK spot intervention, we adjusted for FX valuations, coupons receipts and FX bond issuance and maturities. For MAS spot intervention, we adjusted for FX valuations, coupons receipts and outstanding amount of Reserves Management Government Securities. For BI spot intervention, we adjusted for FX valuations, coupons, receipts and FX bond issuance and maturities, FX term deposits, and government foreign currency loans. FX forwards for May are available for the CBC (+USD0.02bn) and BOT (+USD0.6bn), and based on our estimates for BI (using FX swaps; -USD0.5bn).

Appendix A-1

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